Regev, fifty-one, spent the first two decades of her career in the military, rising through the ranks until she became the IDF spokesperson in 2005. She left the army two years later and quickly moved into politics, entering the Knesset in 2009 and making a name for herself by inciting against Sudanese and Eritrean asylum-seekers. Calling them a “cancer in our body”, she warned that they were part of a left-wing plot to destroy Israel’s Jewish identity. (She later apologized, to cancer patients.) By the time Likud held primaries in the winter of 2014, Regev had risen to number five on its list, ahead of party stalwarts and respected officials like Defense Minister Moshe Ya’alon. She campaigned aggressively for the Likud during election season—not only in conservative constituencies, but again in hostile territory, like a gay bar in Tel Aviv.

Her reward was the culture ministry, which put her in charge of a small department with a roughly $119 million budget, 0.01 per cent of total state spending. The ministry distributes some of that money to hundreds of cultural institutions and art schools, which cover the rest of their budget through private donations, tuition, and ticket sales. It hardly seems like a prestigious job. Her predecessor, Limor Livnat, retired from politics in 2014 after a mostly forgettable six-year stint at the ministry. But it was a perfect fit for Regev, a politician cut from the mold of Donald Trump or Nigel Farage, since it gave her a chance to clash regularly with “the left”, and to make headlines for doing it.

One of her first acts was to temporarily defund the Midan Theater in Haifa, which had put on a play about a Palestinian prisoner who killed an Israeli soldier. Regev accused the theater of trying to “undermine the state”. She also asked Ayelet Shaked, the justice minister, to investigate whether the theater had any “ties to terrorism”, a groundless allegation that went nowhere. The funding decision was quickly reversed, too: the attorney general at the time, Yehuda Weinstein, ruled that it would limit freedom of expression.

Still, it was an early shot across the bow. She followed up in January by trying to create a legal basis for future funding cuts, drafting a “loyalty bill” that would allow her ministry to defund artists who acted “against the principles of the state”. The language was broadly worded. It would apply to performers who incited violence, a reasonable provision, but also to those who desecrated the Israeli flag or commemorated the *nakba*, the mass displacement of Palestinians that accompanied the state’s founding in 1948.